

CV CHECKLIST 2026

The Ultimate International CV Optimization Checklist (UK • USA • Canada • Australia • Europe)

SECTION 1: STRUCTURE & FORMAT CHECK

- ■ CV length is appropriate (UK/Australia/Europe: 1–2 pages, USA: 1 page early career, Canada: 1–2 pages)
- ■ Clear section order: Name & Contact, Professional Summary, Work Experience, Education, Skills, Certifications, Projects, Additional Information
- ■ No unnecessary sections like Objective (unless entry-level), irrelevant hobbies, or listed references

SECTION 2: CONTACT INFORMATION

- ■ Full Name (large and bold at top)
- ■ Professional email address (no nicknames)
- ■ Phone number with international country code
- ■ LinkedIn profile with clean URL
- ■ Portfolio or GitHub link (for technical roles)
- ■ Avoid personal data such as date of birth, religion, marital status, passport number, or full home address

SECTION 3: PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

- ■ 3–5 lines maximum
- ■ Clear job role positioning
- ■ Years of experience stated
- ■ Key strengths highlighted
- ■ Career focus aligned with target role

Example: Cybersecurity Analyst with 3+ years of experience in network security and vulnerability assessment. Skilled in Cisco networking, SIEM tools, and penetration testing. Seeking entry-level security analyst role in the UK tech sector.

SECTION 4: WORK EXPERIENCE

- ■ Include job title, company name, location, and dates (Month Year – Month Year)
- ■ Use bullet points starting with action verbs
- ■ Quantify achievements with measurable results
- ■ Align responsibilities with target job role
- ■ Avoid paragraphs, weak verbs, and responsibility-only descriptions

SECTION 5: SKILLS SECTION

- ■ Divide skills into Technical Skills and Soft Skills
- ■ List tools, platforms, programming languages, and software

- ■ Ensure skills match the job description
- ■ Avoid generic skills without evidence

SECTION 6: EDUCATION

- ■ Degree name
- ■ University name
- ■ Location
- ■ Graduation year
- ■ Optional: GPA, relevant coursework, final project

SECTION 7: COUNTRY-SPECIFIC OPTIMIZATION

- ■ UK: No photo, no date of birth, 1–2 pages, achievement-focused bullets
- ■ USA: No personal info, 1 page (early career), strong metrics, ATS keywords
- ■ Canada: Similar to USA, volunteer experience valued, concise bullets
- ■ Australia: 2 pages common, strong summary and skills section
- ■ Europe: Varies by country; neutral international format is safest (no photo, minimal personal data)

SECTION 8: ATS OPTIMIZATION CHECK

- ■ Use keywords from the job description
- ■ Avoid tables, graphics, and complex layouts
- ■ Do not place text inside images
- ■ Use standard fonts like Arial, Calibri, or Helvetica
- ■ Save as PDF unless employer requests Word format

SECTION 9: LANGUAGE & PROFESSIONALISM

- ■ No spelling or grammar errors
- ■ Consistent formatting and date style
- ■ Professional and concise tone throughout

SECTION 10: DESIGN & READABILITY

- ■ Clean white background
- ■ Consistent spacing and margins
- ■ Clear section headings
- ■ Font size between 10–12pt
- ■ Aligned and readable bullet points

SECTION 11: ENTRY-LEVEL CANDIDATES

- ■ Include internships and academic projects

- ■ List certifications and volunteer work
- ■ Add relevant coursework aligned to the role

SECTION 12: CYBERSECURITY / TECH-SPECIFIC CHECK

- ■ List tools such as Wireshark, Cisco, SIEM, Python
- ■ Include certifications (CCNA, Security+, CEH, etc.)
- ■ Describe technical projects with measurable results
- ■ Include GitHub or portfolio link
- ■ Show a clear specialization focus

SECTION 13: FINAL REVIEW BEFORE SUBMITTING

- ■ Tailor CV to each job role
- ■ Rename file professionally (e.g., John-Smith-Cybersecurity-Analyst-CV.pdf)
- ■ Align job title with application role
- ■ Confirm formatting consistency

BONUS: HIGH-CONVERSION STRATEGY

- Tailor your CV for every application
- Mirror keywords from the job description
- Quantify achievements with data
- Keep formatting clean and ATS-friendly
- Position your expertise clearly and confidently

FINAL REMINDER

Your CV is not a biography. It is a marketing document. Its primary objective is simple: to secure interviews, not to tell your life story.